NORMAN TAFL

A symmetric tafl game for two players

Two players | Ages ten and up | Thirty to forty-five minutes

Both sides are identical: each has a king and twenty pawns. The two kings start **stacked on the central square**. Bring your king to a corner, or capture the enemy king.

Components

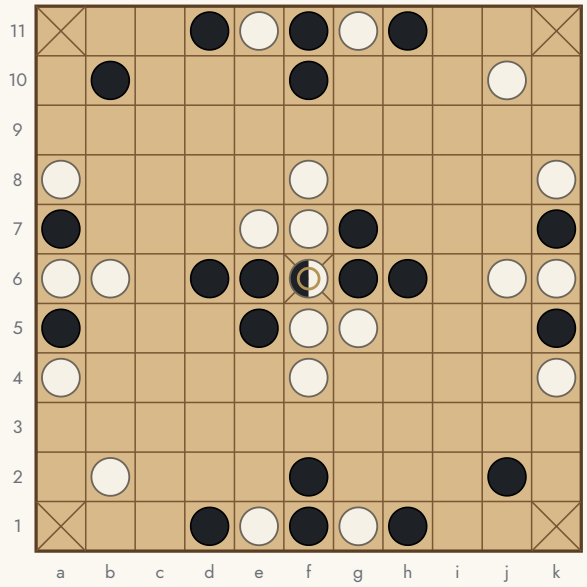
- A square board, eleven squares a side. Files run from **a** to **k**, ranks from **1** to **11**.
- Twenty black pawns and a black king, twenty white pawns and a white king.
- Five **special squares**, marked with a cross: the four corners and the **throne**, the central square f6.

Aim of the game

Bring your king to a **corner**, or **capture the enemy king**. You also win if your opponent cannot move.

Set-up

Place the pieces as in figure 1. The two kings stacked on f6 form the **pair**.



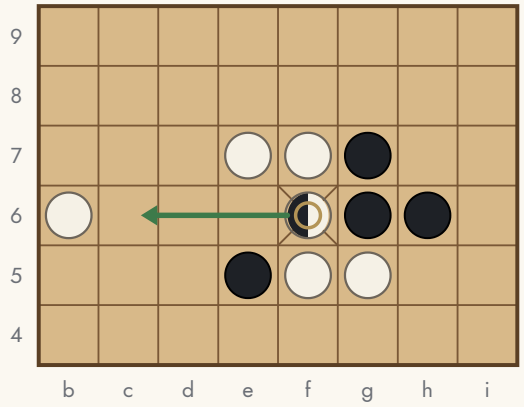
1 Start. The crosses mark the special squares: the four corners and the throne f6.

Your turn

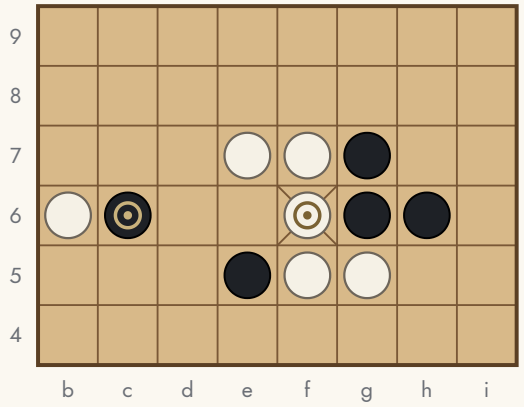
- **Black plays first**, then players alternate.
- Move one of your pieces in a straight line, sideways or up and down, over as many empty squares as you like. Pieces never jump.
- No piece may stop on the throne f6, but pieces may cross it when it is empty.
- Only kings may enter a corner.

The pair

As long as the two kings are stacked on f6, neither king moves on its own. Either player may move the pair. The first to do so **takes his own king along** and **leaves the enemy king on f6**.



2 Black moves the pair from f6 to c6.



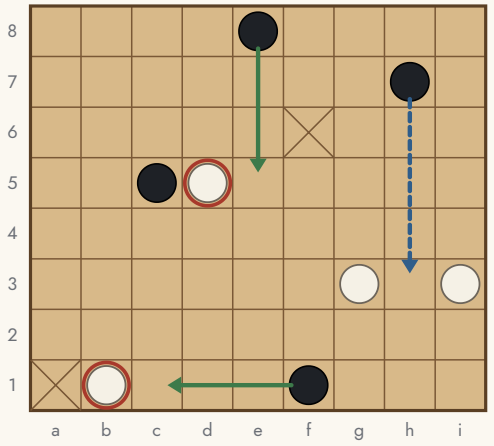
3 The black king is on c6; the white king stays on f6.

THE KEY IDEA

Both kings start from the same square. Leaving first gives you the initiative but exposes your king. Staying on f6 keeps it safe, but lets your opponent choose his moment.

Capturing

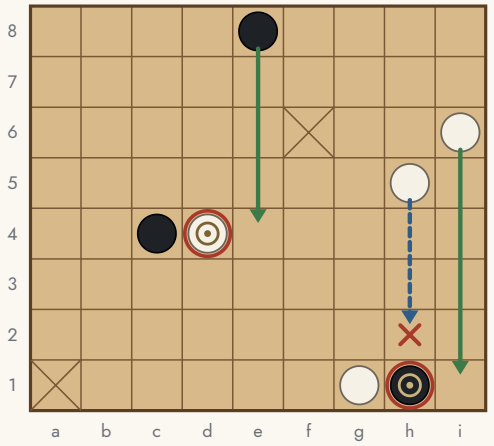
- A pawn that moves next to an enemy piece captures it if, right behind that piece on the same line, there is **one of your pawns** or **an empty special square** (a corner, or the empty throne). The piece is removed.
- One move can capture several pieces.
- Only pawns capture. A king never captures and never helps to capture.
- Moving between two enemy pieces is safe.



4 Black captures d5 (against c5) and b1 (against the empty corner a1). On h3, the black pawn moves between two white pawns and is not captured.

The king

- The king is captured like a pawn: between two enemy pawns, or between an enemy pawn and an empty special square.
- On the throne f6 it **cannot be captured**. Nor can the pair.
- On an edge, it can only be captured **along the edge**.



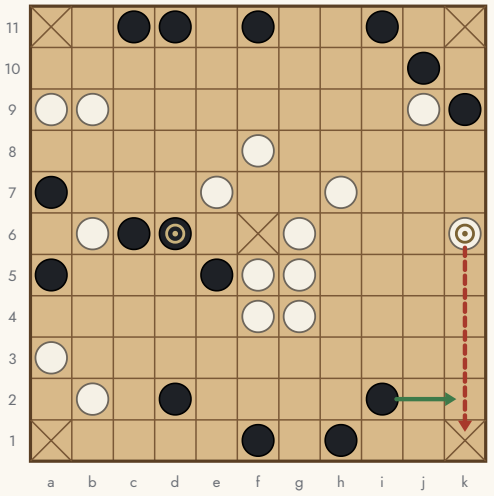
5 The white king on d4 and the black king on h1 are captured. A white pawn moving to h2 would not capture the black king: the edge does not count.

The threat rule

- If your opponent could win on his next move, by reaching a corner or by capturing your king, you must **stop the threat**. A move that leaves him an immediate win is not allowed.
- If no move stops it, you lose at once: an **unstoppable win**.

End of the game

- **Win**: your king reaches a corner, you capture the enemy king, or your opponent has no allowed move.
- **Draw**: the same position occurs for the third time, with the same player to move.



6 The white king threatens to reach k1. Black has a single allowed move: i2-k2, which closes the k-file.

GETTING STARTED

- Before each move, look at the **straight lines leading to the corners**, for both kings.
- A pawn standing **next to an empty corner** can be captured by a single enemy pawn.
- **Material matters**: every captured pawn brings you clearly closer to victory.
- With fewer pawns than your opponent, **keep your king on f6**: taking it out to rescue a lost position usually fails.